

Trigger Happy

Also Remember...

- Memory upgrade could be available in the form of a Compact Flash card, Smart Media or Sony's Memory Stick. Some cameras don't allow upgrading, which is a severe limitation.
- Optical zooming is all that counts. Don't take the electronic zoom function too seriously.
- Floppies for storage aren't a great idea because they tend to be very unreliable, not to mention the limited capacity.
- Look for features such as printing directly from the camera through a special cable, taking sepia photographs, setting the shutter speed, selecting macro modes, auto focus, etc. Some cameras even let you capture short video clips.

As little as two years ago anyone buying a digital camera would have had to put down as much as Rs 50,000 for a VGA camera with just 2-4 MB of storage space. These early models were very inefficient in power usage and tended to need a replacement of batteries after every few shots. Other features such as zooming, which are common in regular cameras, were also missing. However, in the current market, most mainstream cameras give you mega-pixel resolution (more than 1 million pixels), better battery life and even optical zoom lenses, all for as little as Rs 25,000. While Kodak and Sony are the leading manufacturers, Models from Nikon, Olympus and Epson are also available.

TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT

Sensor type: Digital cameras (or film-less cameras) use either a CCD or CMOS sensor which captures light and converts it into electrical charge to capture an image. CCD sensors lead to higher quality images. The size of a CCD sensor is approximately 4.4x6.6 mm as against the 24x36 mm size of the regular film.

SMART TIPS

Resolution: This is often expressed in megapixels. For example, 2.1 megapixels correspond to about 1600x1200 pixels.

Memory: Since cameras come with limited built-in memory (between 8-16 MB), this becomes a limitation when you are taking photos at higher resolution settings. At 1600x1200 you'd be able to store just one or two images in the TIFF format.

Interface: Connection to the computer is via USB or parallel port. The USB interface is preferable due to greater convenience and higher data rates.

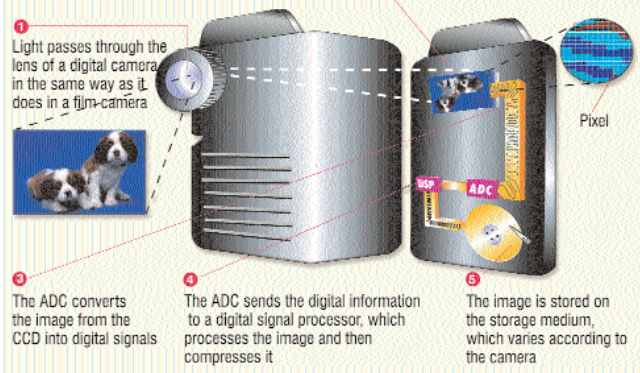
Power: You will need a set of rechargeable batteries because the consumption tends to be high, especially

when you are using the LCD viewfinder. Some manufacturers ship their cameras with power adapters which is pretty useful when you are shooting indoors.

Separate monochrome display: It makes sense to have a separate monochrome display for camera status when you are trying to conserve your batteries by switching off the LCD screen.

Viewfinder: Some cameras have a regular viewfinder in addition to the small LCD screen that also serves this purpose.

HOW A DIGITAL CAMERA WORKS



	Casual user	Photography enthusiast	Professional
You need	To be able to take photos to compile personal albums or publish to the Web	High-quality images which you intend to print.	Very high quality photographs with onboard adjustment for colour and contrast
Look for	Between 640x480 and 1024x768 resolution and 2 MB memory; maybe one that doubles as a Web cam	1280x1024 resolution with at least 2x optical zoom and 8 MB storage	2048x2048 or higher with special lens options and a minimum 16 MB memory
Our pick	Intel Pocket PC Camera	Sony DSC-PI, Canon PowerShot A10, Kodak DC3200	Nikon D1X (not available in India)
Price range	Around Rs 10,000	Up to Rs 60,000	Not available



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